

the years of sacrifice and the hard work I had already put in. There was no other option for me but to be successful. I grew up in a generation where Indian athletes were perceived to be submissive and a bit soft, and that's one of the reasons why I became so rugged. That's one of the reasons why I could come back from losing matches or get through the hard years of missing home. It was not easy to be far away from home and miss out on several festivals and occasions, be it birthdays, anniversaries, Christmas, New Year's, or Diwali. I gave up my whole youth and a lot of family life for 38 years and dedicated everything to my sport and craft. Everything was dedicated to my country and our people.

Does it hurt to see that nobody has carried forward your legacy? What's ailing Indian tennis today?

I feel sad right now, looking at the state of Indian tennis. It's sad to see that the tradition has not been continued. That being said, I have tremendous respect for the players who, without funding, a support system, or any real guidance, are still out there, persevering to pursue a professional tennis career, even though there are so many other options that are out there that are even better or safer.

So, it almost seems like it has come back to square one. I played across three decades, but now we are back to a phase where individuals are trying to muster up the courage, the finances, the knowledge, and the support system to be even out there. Individual tennis players have come out and said, 'I need funding' and that's a sad realisation.

Tennis is one of the toughest sports on the planet. As a sport, it is demanding, and it's also hard physically, mentally, and financially.

A lot of sports are moving to crowd-funding models these days. Is that the way forward for Indian tennis as well?

When you are looking at any form of funding, people are looking for returns on that funding. They're not running a charity. They're looking for

some sort of marketing behind it, some sort of publicity behind it, and some sort of return on the money that they spend on it. Otherwise, they would rather put it in the equity market, where they get a solid return. So, in that sense, it's also an ecosystem that needs to be created, not just for tennis but for all Olympic sports. The BCCI is doing a phenomenal job with the system that they've created to not just look after their past champions and their past cricketers, but to also nurture the present athletes and, more importantly, to create over 100,000 cricket clubs around the country. Today, I would be surprised if there were even 100,000 tennis players in the country!

And here, you have 100,000 cricket clubs, so a minimum of 11 in each club. So, you see the numbers that are being churned and produced. Very much like tennis, cricket is not a cheap sport; you need a kit, and then there are coaching, diet, and transportation costs. BCCI's model can be replicated by the governing bodies of other sports.

Do you think that at a time when Indian tennis is at a crossroads, a legend like you should perhaps get into administration and try to get the house in order?

My expertise lies in the nurturing of talent and sports education. So, I have a business model where I am taking my father's (Dr Vece Paes) sixty years of sports science, my Olympic-winning mentality knowledge, and clubbing knowledge and spreading it to the youth of the entire country through sports education in schools, colleges, tier-2 and tier-3 centres, and in rural areas.

I think our real sporting talent lies in those rural areas.

In the metros, the kids have more options — eSports or gaming — but the options are still limited in rural areas. So, that's where I want to cater. I want to go out there, recognise talents, test those talents, nurture them, and ensure that they are injury-free with the help of sports science. It's a long process, as you are picking kids when they are young, and it takes hours and hours to create champions out of them.

But then, if Leander Paes can mentor Stefanos Tsitsipas, why can't he work more closely with the current Indian players? Do they not approach you?

(Laughs) I get calls from Prajnesh (Gunneswaran), and he would ask about his equipment or from Arjun Kadhe, who talks about his fitness regime. I get calls from a lot of youngsters who ask about their physical fitness, mental fitness, or diet, but it's just that we don't speak about it. That's personal friendship. Tsitipas' manager called me to work with him, and it was a learning experience.

But at the end of the day, my work involves the masses, and it's about going out there and nurturing talents. One has lived at the top of the pyramid for three decades, so he knows how to pick athletes as and when they develop and create a winning atmosphere for them. So, whether it was speaking to RVS Rathore at the opening ceremony of the Sydney Olympics about the mental side of things or when he finally won his medal, he said, 'Hey Lee, thanks so much...', so those are the things you do out of friendship.

You are asking me, What's wrong



I can't expect people to understand what my journey was. I felt it was better to lead by example than waste time explaining it